

Gaming Through Isolation: Video Games as a Coping Strategy for Social Isolation
A Study that explores how video games can help people cope with social isolation by providing social interaction, companionship, and a sense of belonging through virtual communities.

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INTRODUCTION

Social isolation is a significant issue that affects people of different ages and backgrounds, often leading to feelings of loneliness, disconnection, and a lack of belonging. When individuals have limited opportunities to interact with others, they may struggle to build and maintain meaningful relationships, which can negatively affect their emotional and social well-being. In today's digital age, technology has created new ways for people to connect, and one of these is through video games. While video games are commonly viewed as a form of entertainment, they can also provide opportunities for communication, cooperation, friendship, and social interaction. Multiplayer games, online communities, and gaming platforms allow individuals to interact with others who share similar interests, even when they are physically separated. For some people, these virtual connections can provide companionship and a sense of belonging during periods of social isolation. However, gaming can have both positive and negative effects depending on how it is used. This presentation explores video games as a coping strategy for social isolation, focusing on how gaming can help individuals build social connections, reduce feelings of loneliness, and maintain interaction with others while also recognizing the importance of balancing virtual relationships with real-world connections.

PROBLEM DESCRIPTION

Social isolation and loneliness are significant public health concerns that can negatively affect a person's mental and physical well-being. According to the World Health Organization (WHO, 2025), approximately 1 in 6 people worldwide experience loneliness, with adolescents and young adults reporting particularly high rates. The WHO also emphasizes that social isolation and loneliness can have serious effects on mental health, physical health, quality of life, and longevity.

As technology becomes increasingly integrated into everyday life, video games may provide an additional way for socially isolated individuals to interact and connect with others. Multiplayer games and online gaming communities can allow players to communicate, cooperate, develop friendships, and experience a sense of social connection. However, research does not support the idea that gaming automatically reduces loneliness. A systematic review and meta-analysis by Luo et al. (2022) examined 18 studies involving 20,372 participants and found mixed results regarding the relationship between video-game participation and

loneliness. The researchers concluded that there was insufficient evidence to establish a definitive relationship between the two.

Therefore, the problem is not simply whether people should play video games, but how video games can be used appropriately as a coping strategy for social isolation. When gaming encourages social interaction and connection, it may provide an additional source of companionship and belonging. At the same time, excessive or primarily solitary gaming may not address the underlying causes of social isolation. Understanding this distinction is important in determining how video games can potentially support social well-being without replacing meaningful real-world relationships.

PROPOSED SOLUTION

Single-player games can serve as a coping strategy for individuals experiencing social isolation by providing entertainment, relaxation, emotional engagement, and a temporary escape from feelings of loneliness. Games such as *Journey*, *Spirittfarer*, *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild*, *Marvel's Spider-Man*, and *Stardew Valley* allow players to explore immersive worlds, follow meaningful stories, and connect emotionally with characters without requiring direct interaction with other players. These games can provide a sense of accomplishment and purpose through completing quests, overcoming challenges, and progressing through the story. However, they should be used as a healthy form of recreation rather than as a replacement for real-world social relationships.

In addition, multiplayer games can provide a more direct way of coping with social isolation by creating opportunities for *communication, cooperation, teamwork, and friendship*. Games such as *Minecraft*, *Among Us*, *Overcooked! 2*, *It Takes Two*, *Fortnite*, and *Roblox* allow players to interact with friends or other players while working toward shared goals. For example, *Minecraft* allows players to build and explore together, while *It Takes Two* requires two players to communicate and cooperate throughout the game. These shared experiences can help individuals develop social connections and create a sense of belonging. However, multiplayer gaming should be balanced with face-to-face relationships and other offline activities so that virtual interaction complements rather than replaces real-world connections.

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, video games can serve as a valuable coping strategy for social isolation when used in a healthy and balanced way. Single-player games can provide relaxation, emotional engagement, entertainment, and a sense of achievement, while multiplayer games can create opportunities for communication, teamwork, friendship, and a sense of belonging. Although video games cannot completely replace meaningful real-world relationships, they can serve as a bridge that helps individuals feel connected and less alone. By promoting responsible gaming habits and balancing virtual interactions with offline relationships and activities, video games can become a positive tool for supporting emotional well-being and reducing the effects of social isolation.

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